

Is Homeownership Reaching its Limits?

A Historical and Contemporary Review of Path Dependency in Belgium's Housing Landscape.

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The Belgian housing landscape, primarily driven by homeownership, is the result of what De Decker (2011) describes as: “a long-standing dialectical process of political choices and actions, cultural convictions, and economic possibilities, which have reinforced each other over and over again through and in daily practice”. This evolution has been steered by three primary historical paths: policies designed to keep workers out of the city by subsidizing mass mobility, housing policies actively supporting homeownership and lastly an absence of formal planning instruments. Together, these paths have established a rigid path dependency, positioning owner-occupied detached housing as the norm in the Belgian housing landscape.

Today, the Belgian asset-based welfare model is reaching its structural limits. Although homeownership remains a multifaceted tool, serving as an investment, a ‘piggy bank,’ and a desired life goal, the convergence of rising property prices, an unregulated rental market, and a limited social housing stock is significantly widening the gap in housing affordability. Spatially, this has resulted in a fragmented and diffused landscape where, over time, the interplay between self-reinforcing paths has produced an environment shaped not by an overarching planning vision, but rather by an accumulation of individual, rational decisions. Consequently, Flanders now faces the highest land take in the European Union, leading to severe environmental risks.

Recognizing these path dependencies is essential for steering the current housing model towards a more sustainable direction. To do this, we will trace the three historical paths to understand their origins. Next, the contemporary socio-economic and spatial implications of their convergence are analyzed. Finally, a multi-faceted prospective vision is proposed. This includes strengthening the private rental market, adopting alternative ownership structures and rethinking the urban-rural dichotomy. By steering these paths through grounded and multifaceted solutions, the dependencies of the current homeownership and asset-based welfare model can be transitioned into a catalyst for future spatial and social equity.

1. Historical Overview

To better understand the Belgian housing model, De Decker (2008) identifies three historical structuring tracks that established the path dependency we are confronted with today: policies designed to keep workers out of the cities through subsidized mass mobility, the active promotion of home ownership and the absence of formal spatial planning instruments. De Decker (2011) continues: “It is the result of a long-standing dialectical process of political choices and actions, cultural convictions, and economic possibilities, which have reinforced each other over and over again through and in daily practice”.

While many nations remain influenced by early housing policy decisions, Belgium’s paths are characterized by the detached, owner-occupied home. Mougenot (1988) emphasizes the historical continuity of this model, highlighting that the free single family home has become a universal norm and the accepted reference to which the majority aims for. While these paths don’t strictly dictate the future, they establish the boundaries for current and future development (Kleinman, 1996). Therefore, unwinding these historical paths to their fundamental structures is essential to understanding contemporary challenges and identifying viable remedies.

Path A. Subsidized Commuting



Fig 1.
View from a tram, somewhere between
Wange and Ezemaal on the Overhespen -
Jodoigne tramway.
(Van Dam, 1959)

Within the context of a young, industrializing Belgian state led by opposing Catholic and Liberal ideologies, a shared interest emerged in dispersing the working-class population through (vicinal) railways and specific housing policies (Witte & Keuleers, 1985). The high concentration of workers and impoverished conditions in coal-mining and industrial centers led to poor hygiene and several cholera epidemics, which the urban bourgeoisie perceived as a direct threat (De Decker, 2011). Simultaneously, the privatisation of the commons through the laws of 1804 (appropriation of commons by municipalities) and 1847 (forced privatisation of uncultivated land) during the potato crisis, pushed rural dwellers into poor living conditions, forcing them to urban areas (Aernouts, n.d.). As these industrial and urban agglomerations became perceived as a hotbed of socialist revolts, they posed a serious threat to the long-standing moral authority of the Catholics.

Against this backdrop, both Catholics and Liberals found common ground in the strategic displacement of workers to the countryside. However, as De Decker (2011) notes, this created a paradox: “in order to keep the populace obedient and humble, the workers should be kept in their villages; but in order to keep the economy going, they had to work in the cities”.

It is striking that legislation for mobility and commuting preceded housing laws; the foundation of the National Railway Company (1834), the introduction of the social railway tariff in (1869) and the foundation of the national light National Light Railway Company (1884) and the first housing law in 1889. Notably, the introduction of the social railway tariff and light railway company were instrumental, as they enabled the working class to reside in the countryside while commuting to urban or industrialized areas. This effectively acted as a countermeasure against significant urban expansion (De Meulder et al. 2000). Furthermore, these cheap commuter rates created a dispersed and mobile workforce, allowing workers to access land that was considerably cheaper than urban plots. As Rowntree observed (1910, p. 508): “The possession of these gardens, so highly prized by the working-class population, is rendered possible by the system of cheap railway tickets, which enable men to live at some distance from their work in districts where land is comparatively cheap.” Ultimately, this deliberately instituted home-work split resulted in a spatial-fix: anchoring the working-class population in the countryside while ensuring their continued participation in the national economy (Schepers et al., 2020).

This facilitated social and spatial mobility served as a crucial enabler for subsequent paths. The convergence of accessible rural land, subsidized transit, and higher urban wages established the socio-economic foundation for a model centered on individual homeownership, a preference that would later be embedded into a core pillar of the Belgian identity. Although the infrastructural basis for the mass mobility has shifted through time from the (vicinal) railways to a dense road network and individual car ownership, the underlying spatial-fix is still present to this day (De Decker, 2011; De Meulder et al. 2000). It is this rooted focus on mobility that provided part of the strategic framework for the housing policies that followed.

Following the formation of the Belgian Labour Party in 1885 and the widespread workers’ uprisings of 1886, the first Housing Law was passed in 1889, establishing the framework for promoting homeownership in Belgium. The underlying rationale was that providing cheap social loans and tax incentives would discourage workers from striking or organizing; burdened by mortgage obligations and centered on Catholic family ideals, they were expected to prioritize domestic stability over political activism (De Decker, 2011; Kesteloot & De Maesschalck, 2001; Mougnot, 1988). This strategy persisted through the interwar period, notably with the 1922 Moyersoen law, which provided purchase and construction grants for new dwellings (De Meulder et al. 2000). The model was further reinforced in 1928 with the creation of the Housing Fund for Large Families, which provided cheap loans to large households, further institutionalizing the ownership model (De Decker, 2008).



Fig 2.
Kaart der Belgische buurtspoorwegen in 1922
(Nationale Maatschappij van Buurtspoorwegen, 1922)



Fig. 3
A sugar beet tram from Jodoigne crosses the Tienen - Sint-Truiden (- Liège) high-way at Overhespen.
(Louwerse, 1959)

Path B. Promoting Homeownership



Fig 4.
The Strike (1886) by R. Koehler.



Fig 5.
Minister of Health Alfred De Taeye in Waregem, at a ceremony for the hundred thousandth home in 1954 (Canon van Vlaanderen, 2026).



Fig 5.
Billboard highlighting a building project for detached dwellings in Turnhout, 1990s Canon van Vlaanderen, 2026).

In the meantime, alternatives rooted in socialist ideals began to emerge, notably through the establishment of the National Housing Company (NMGWW) in 1919, which focused on planned social neighborhoods and garden city projects. However, the owner-occupied model was further reinforced in 1936 with the creation of the National Society for Small-scale Land Ownership (NMKL) under the socialist leader Hendrik De Man, which exclusively supported the owner-occupied housing model by providing social loans. The target group were specifically unemployed workers who were encouraged to leave the city to live in rural communes or urban fringes where they could combine housing with small-scale gardening (De Decker, 2008; Mougénot, 1988). These initiatives were underpinned by divergent political narratives; Catholics maintained an anti-urban attitude; Socialists aimed to improve the living conditions of the working class (Kesteloot & De Maesschalck, 2001). Interestingly however, the opposing political pillars sometimes converged during this interbellum period, both promoting and stimulating “a return to the fields” by supporting home ownership in some way or another (De Meulder et al. 2000; Mougénot, 1988).

This general trend of home ownership goes hand in hand with the construction of the postwar welfare state. This period was marked by two major housing acts: De Taeye law in 1948 and the Brunfaut law in 1949. The Catholic De Taeye law proved to be very successful by providing generous grants for households to purchase or self-build a new dwelling. Much like previous legislation, these developments did not follow a general planning scheme but relied on private individual initiative (Heynen, 2010). De Taeye explicitly linked property to moral development, stating: “The small owner feels responsible for the continuation of his property [...] Responsibility and self-reliance are at the basis of the development of the human person, which is our highest goal” (Strauven, 1983, as cited in Heynen, 2010, p. 173). While the Brunfaut Law served as the socialist response by creating a framework for renting, purchasing and constructing social housing, the De Taeye law emerged as the far more influential of the two, effectively institutionalizing homeownership as the cornerstone of the Belgian housing system (Aernouts, n.d.).

This construction of the asset-based welfare state and the institutionalization of homeownership further intensified during the postwar decades. During the transition to a post-fordist society in the 1970s and 80s, this model served a dual purpose: it acted as a socio-economic buffer for a growing workforce while simultaneously functioning as an economic engine, as individual house construction became a major driver of national investment and employment (De Decker & Dewilde, 2010; Geurts & Goossens, 2004). The house effectively became a ‘piggy bank’ that is transferred from generation to generation, keeping this tradition alive and deeply rooted (Aernouts, n.d.).

This tradition created a strong path dependency. While access to affordable land, subsidy policies, tax deductions and generalized mobility, maintained relative housing affordability for a significant portion of the population (Dehaene, 2013), this model simultaneously reinforced social inequalities. These policies often trigger a “Matthew effect”, where financial support primarily benefited the middle class with existing capital, while leaving lower-income households, who lacked the means to enter the ownership market, dependent on a precarious and often poor-quality rental sector (Aernouts & Ryckewaert, 2018; Fikse & Aalbers, 2021; Geurts & Goossens, 2004).

Until the first spatial planning law in 1962, there were no formal planning laws or overarching spatial vision. The previous laws promoted the construction of new homes through ownership, but gave no guidance on where these new homes should be placed. There was no accompanying legal planning framework, relying instead on piecemeal, bottom-up initiatives following the strongest political pillar. As Heynen (2010) notes, these conflicting ideologies were precisely why centralized planning regulations failed to materialize.

Grosjean (2010) highlights that before the De Taeye law in 1949, the combination of generalized mobility, the promotion of home ownership and the absence of formal planning methods led to an “urbanisation without urbanism”. While political and financial incentives existed to disperse the population over the countryside through ownership, these still relied on individual incentives and lacked a coherent planning vision on where or how to build. This “laissez-faire” approach allowed urbanization to emerge organically within the existing fabric rather than through large city agglomerations, which undermined the necessity for creating urban planning policies (De Meulder et al. 2000). However, this form of urbanization was still very different to the Belgian sprawl we know today. The homes built following the law of 1889, remained articulated in relation to the existing road, the neighbors, and village centres (De Meulder et al. 2000). These developments functioned as a form of infill, densifying the existing urban tissue and causing villages to agglomerate internally rather than expanding into the open landscape (Grosjean, 2012).

Path C. Planning Regulation and Spatial Outcome

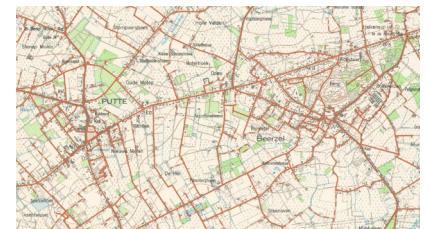
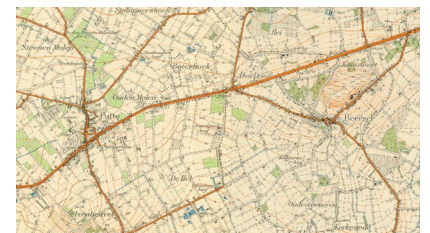


Fig 6-10. NGI basemaps from 1939, 1969, and 1989, along with a high-resolution aerial orthophoto from 2015, highlighting the continued fragmented articulation of village centers and the rise of single-plot dwellings (Historical OSM, 2026).



Fig 11.
A freestanding house, quite literally
turning its back to the street. Own work.

This urbanization pattern started to change with the De Taeye law in 1949, the following first spatial law in 1962 and the increase in car ownership. The housing patterns emerging from the De Taeye law were much more focused on decoupled, freestanding housing on large plots, turning its back to the street and village (De Meulder et al. 2000). The urbanisation started to decouple from the village centre, leading to the diffused condition and sprawl we know today. The Spatial Planning Act of 1962 introduced for the first time instruments like building permits, subdivision permits and plans at various levels. As De Decker (2011) notes, this postwar construction boom took place without almost no spatial planning instruments available. And even when these were available after 1962, the local municipalities lacked the necessary experience to correctly evaluate the submitted building permits in relation to a broader urban logic. To keep land prices low, large residential zones were demarcated, creating ample reserves of land. In addition, the existing and emerging sprawl patterns like ribbon development were locked in place with these zoning plans (Lacoere et al., 2023). Creating a very strong path dependency of which we see its effects today.

2. Contemporary Overview

These three historical paths: subsidized commuting, the active promotion of homeownership and the absence of spatial planning instruments, did not only serve ideological or economical motives. Over time, these paths reinforced one another, quite literally converging and materializing into the unique socio-economic and spatial landscape we face today. This materialization creates a powerful path dependency. The free standing house not only serves as a dwelling but has become a multifaceted tool: an investment, the piggy bank, the heritage, and a core pillar of the Belgian identity. To understand the contemporary implications of this convergence, it is useful to analyse current homeownership trends through a socio-economic and spatial lens. Such an assessment is necessary to navigate future transitions as these paths continue to exert an inertia on any attempt to steer towards a more sustainable socio-economic and spatial order.

Socio-economic lens

While homeownership in Flanders stood at approximately 40% in 1947, it rose to over 70% fifty years later (Geurts & Goossens, 2004). In 2020, 78% of Flemings owned their home, compared to 69% in Wallonia, 65% in the Netherlands, 65% in the UK, 64% in France, and 51% in Germany, highlighting the historical focus of supporting homeownership (Heylen, 2023). According to a report by the National Bank of Belgium (Warisse, 2022), more than 70% of Belgian households are currently homeowners. Although this level has remained relatively stable over the past two decades, a gradual recent downtrend has been observed. Meanwhile, inflation-adjusted dwelling prices tripled between 1973 and 2021.

Consequently, the price-to-income ratio, the relationship between dwelling prices and disposable household income, has shown a clear upward trend since the second half of the 1980s. While disposable income continues to grow, it is unable to keep pace with the rising property prices, creating a widening gap in housing affordability (Warisse, 2022).

The mortgage repayment burden highlights that borrowers, particularly younger households lacking sufficient personal funds, experience an increased burden on their monthly disposable income (Warisse, 2022). This pressure is most acute in Brussels and Flemish cities, where dwelling prices are already higher than national average. This trend reflects the dropping homeownership rates among the lowest income groups (lower 60% of median income) where the ownership rate has declined steadily from 56.4 % in 2003 to 36.9 % in 2020 (Warisse, 2022). In addition, Belgium’s elderly population, who have been significantly shaped by homeownership laws, are characterized as income-poor, but asset-rich, possessing low pensions but significant real estate equity that they accumulated over their lifetimes (De Decker & Dewilde, 2010).

This inequality is even more pronounced within the rental market. In Belgium, property is the primary driver of household wealth, and property values in this asset-based welfare market have risen sharply over the past years, placing renters at a disadvantage. While the homeownership rate in Flanders in 1976 was still relatively balanced between the lowest and highest income groups: 60% and 70% respectively, this had diverged by 2013 to 45.3% and 83.4%, revealing a gap of nearly 40 percentage points (Warisse, 2022). Consequently, lower-income households are increasingly pushed into the private rental market, which is characterized by a lack of structural protection, leaving tenants to face unregulated rental prices, tenure insecurity, and significant practical difficulties in enforcing housing quality standards (De Decker, 2011). Furthermore, social renting does not provide a viable alternative for many, as the social housing stock remains limited and waiting times vary between four and ten years (Winters et al., 2024).

This trend is somewhat expected, given the decades of homeownership promotion and the lack of a suitable alternative (De Decker et al., 2011). Furthermore, the Flemish government did not even succeed in increasing home-ownership rates for the lower-income groups (Geurts & Goossens, 2004). While the policies did succeed in achieving high overall ownership rates and relatively good housing conditions, these subsidies primarily benefited middle-class households, which in many cases, could have managed without them (Fikse & Aalbers, 2021; Geurts & Goossens, 2004). Consequently, this has resulted in growing inequality between higher and lower income homeowners, as well as between owners and tenants.

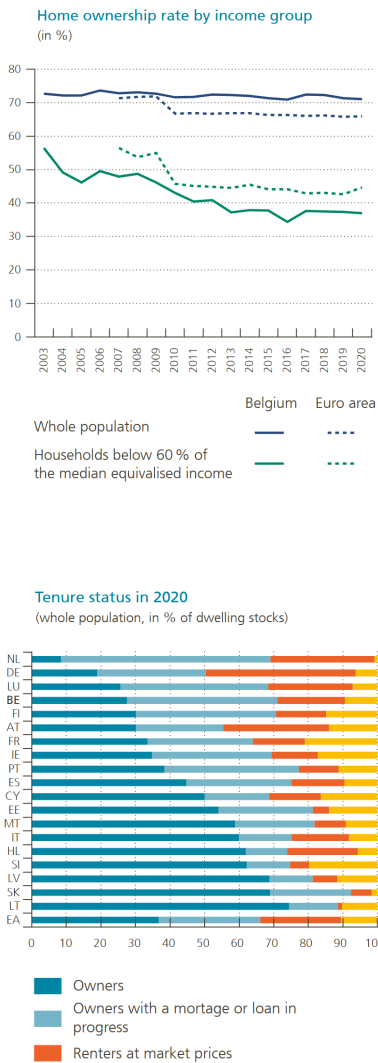


Fig 12-13. Graphs showing the gap in homeownership between the highest and lowest income groups and comparisons between other European countries (Warisse, 2022).

A significant challenge remains that the housing preference for most Belgians is still by far the detached house in a green, non urban area (de Smalen & Van den Broeck, 2025). Non-urban areas consistently score much higher than urban areas in terms of environmental preference, as they are perceived as healthier and more social (Meeus & De Decker, 2015). In addition, homeownership is viewed as a primary life goal and a transition to adulthood. Consequently, with the arrival of children, there is a strong urge to move out of the city (Meeus & De Decker, 2015). Once settled, however, Belgians tend to remain in their home for the rest of their life. Only 20% of Flemings are willing to move when their household size decreases (de Smalen & Van den Broeck, 2025). Due to a deep emotional bond with their property, they often prefer DIY renovations and structural extensions over relocating when their housing needs change (Meeus & De Decker, 2015). Additionally, there is limited interest in alternative housing models, as the majority remains unwilling to share facilities such as gardens or parking spaces. Instead, a strong preference persists for private infrastructure and traditional living arrangements (de Smalen & Van den Broeck, 2025).

These tendencies demonstrate again, how powerful path dependencies can be. Belgians are not born with the ‘brick in the stomach’; rather, this mindset is the result of deep rooted and long-standing policy measures, social norms and practices (Mougenot, 1988). These historical influences shape not only how individuals perceive housing but also how they navigate various other aspects of their lives (Meeus & De Decker, 2015).

Spatial lens



Fig 14.
Land take map of Flanders (Departement Omgeving, 2023)

These path dependencies have not only exerted a profound socio-economic impact but also a lasting spatial influence. Over time, the interplay between these self-reinforcing paths has resulted in a fragmented and diffused landscape that was not shaped by an overarching planning vision, but rather by an accumulation of individual, rational decisions and initiatives. These bottom-up processes have ultimately produced the complex urban form we are confronted with today (Ryckewaert, 2002).

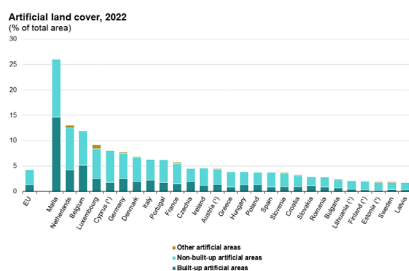


Fig 15.
Artificial land cover, 2022
(% of total area) for European countries
(Eurostat, 2022)

Currently, land take in Flanders stands at 32%, the highest in the European Union (Departement Omgeving, 2023). Housing accounts for 39% of this land take, while roads and railways constitute 19%, both of which continue to rise. Notably, 71% of this housing land take consists of single family homes; among owner-occupied households, this reaches 86% (de Smalen & Van den Broeck, 2025), highlighting the spatial outcome of decades of homeownership promotion. Despite the decline of annual number of new subdivisions and plots, the total subdivided surface area in Flanders continues to increase (Pisman et al., 2016), as the parcelling of new land remains a frequently used planning tool. This ongoing, fragmented expansion hinders sustainable development by creating economic inefficiencies, increasing car dependency, and driving up the cost of public services.

Furthermore, this results in the loss of agricultural land and biodiversity while disrupting the carbon balance. Extensive soil sealing also increases the risks of flooding, water scarcity, and heat stress in heavily paved areas (Lacoere et al., 2023; Pisman et al., 2019).

Efforts were made with the 1997 Spatial Structure Plan for Flanders to counter this sprawl and reduce land take by demarcating growth boundaries and promoting development within designated ‘urban areas’. However, besides other contributing factors, the implementation of this instrument revealed that the rigid urban-rural dichotomy failed to reflect the complex Flemish spatial reality (de Olde, 2022). While it succeeded in slowing down the pace of the sprawl process, it failed to halt ongoing land take and fragmentation (Mustafa & Teller, 2020). More recently, the “bouwshift”, part of the Spatial Policy Plan of Flanders, aims to eliminate daily open space consumption by 2040 through densification and reinforcing existing urban centers. Nevertheless, its implementation is hindered by the high cost of owner compensation, the legal legacy of oversized 1970s development plans, and persistent cultural preferences for single-family homes (de Olde, 2022; Lacoere et al., 2023).

After eight decades of promoting homeownership, the model appears to be reaching its structural limits. While it historically functioned as a private safety net for previous generations by providing high-quality housing, the current reality of high entry barriers, a lack of viable alternatives and negative spatial externalities suggest that the asset-based welfare model is increasingly failing the very population it was designed to protect (De Decker & Dewilde, 2010; Geurts & Goossens, 2004).

3. Prospective Overview

It is evident that these path dependencies are deeply embedded within our structural environment, possessing a physical, economic, political, and societal inertia that persists over time. This is particularly evident in housing policies, which do not only dictate the physical and financial conditions of access to a home, but also serve as a mechanism that shapes how individuals perceive themselves and their social status (De Decker et al., 2011). Recognizing this path dependency is crucial for steering these paths in new directions, rather than attempting to break free through ungrounded policies. Moreover, as these paths permeate all dimensions of society, developing sustainable pathways requires a multi-faceted approach that operates across these various fields simultaneously. The following sections outline several non-exhaustive directions to inspire a divergence from these existing pathways. Understanding homeownership as the cumulative result of past policy decisions allows us to move beyond and focus on offering viable alternatives that lead toward more equitable and sustainable housing.

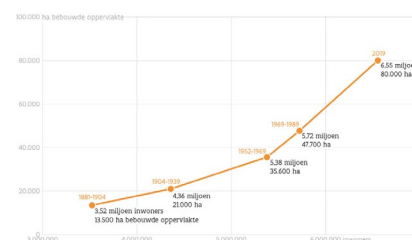


Fig 16.
Evolution of the built up area between 1881 and 2019 (Departement Omgeving, 2021)

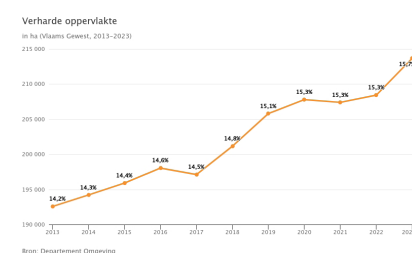


Fig 17.
Evolution of the paved area between 2013 and 2023 (Departement Omgeving, 2025)

Providing suitable alternatives



Fig 18. Collectief Goed in Antwerp addresses the critical housing shortage for large, low-income families by acquiring aging properties through in-kind contributions from social housing partners and renovating them via social work-experience programs. In this project, the model bridges the owner-tenant gap for the lower income groups by translating ownership to co-ownership, where residents purchase shares to gain a vote in the organization's management rather than holding a private deed to a specific property. (Janssens et al., 2020)

Closing the gap between policymakers, specialists and inhabitants



Fig 19. The Atelier BrabantStad project utilized a research by design methodology to transition from traditional zoned planning towards a vision of the regional landscape as a single, cohesive 'carpet'. By organizing collaborative platforms, the project sought to bridge the gap between policymakers, specialists, and inhabitants. It departed from interdependencies between physical landscape drivers and stakeholders to foster a sense of shared ownership and co-creation. This approach enabled the integration of multi-faceted solutions for a broader range of challenges, successfully moving beyond narrow, short-term fixations. (Architecture Workroom Brussels et al., 2014; Viganò et al., 2018, pp. 401–411)

As previously demonstrated, the persistence of the homeownership model can be partly attributed to the lack of viable housing alternatives, a situation that remains very similar today. However, this also implies that providing alternatives now can steer the path in a new direction. Strengthening the private rental market through enhanced regulation is crucial to bridging the socio-economical gap between renters and homeowners. This could be achieved, for instance, by restoring the tenure neutrality by eliminating advantages for homeowners and taxing actual rental income rather than using outdated estimates. Additionally, implementing indicative price grids and quality-based point systems to link rent prices to housing standards could improve both the living standard of renters and the overall quality of rental stock. Finally, using renovation subsidies and strict indexing rules can ensure affordability and stability in the private rental market (Aernouts, n.d.; Vastmans & de Vries, 2011; Winters & Marchal, 2004).

To enhance social housing development, a shift towards intergovernmental coordination and a strategic directorial role for local authorities is essential. This way, cities and municipalities can manage land and administrative processes more effectively, specifically by retaining public land for social projects. Furthermore, social housing targets should be treated as a minimum baseline rather than a limit, supported by regional scaling and proactive communication to improve the public image of the social housing sector (Aernouts, n.d.; Loris et al., 2022; Winters et al., 2024; Winters & Marchal, 2004).

To address the complex housing crisis and facilitate necessary spatial transformations, a shift from top-down policies toward an intensive dialogue between governments, civil society, and residents is essential. Such a collaborative approach is required to escape the 'Joint-Decision Trap', as projects are frequently delayed by fragmented coordination and bureaucratic hurdles rather than a lack of financial means (Winters et al., 2024). Furthermore, there is a clear need for a supralocal housing policy level to bridge the gap between Flemish and local authorities, enabling a shared regional vision that integrates housing with environmental and mobility objectives (De Craene & Ryckewaert, 2020). By integrating local experiential knowledge and transdisciplinary expertise early in the process, policymakers can prevent legal gridlock and build public support for spatial changes (de Olde, 2022). Ultimately, this ensures that housing developments are not mere policy targets, but projects that respect local identity and promote social justice.

Alternative ownership and management structures

These pathways reflect a broader trend towards the decommodification of housing, where the focus shifts from its exchange or market value towards its use value, decoupling property from possession (Aernouts, n.d.). This is often rooted in commoning practices that are a form of self-organizing systems that manage shared resources through community-based rules and social practices (Kuhk et al., 2018). One of the main examples is the Community Land Trust (CLT) model, which separates land ownership from the building itself, ensuring affordability by limiting the resale value and speculation through contractual agreements by the cooperative (Aernouts & Ryckewaert, 2018; Kuhk et al., 2018, pp. 47–49). Similarly, housing cooperatives use collective shareholding and cost-rent principles to offer lower costs than the private market (Kuhk et al., 2018, pp. 47–49). Furthermore, the commons can counteract fragmentation by using partnerships and a process of incremental scaling to reconnect local negotiations over shared land-use rights into a supra-local network, thereby collectively restoring access to open space (Kuhk et al., 2018, pp. 179–183).

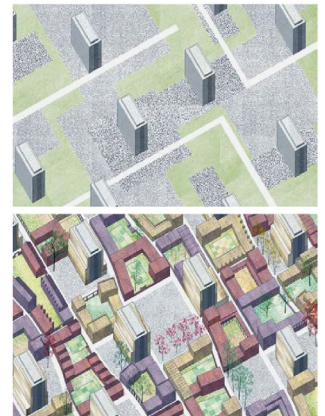


Fig 20.

The ‘Vacante Voorstad’ project in Meulstede Noord in Ghent addresses the poor housing quality and fragmented, in-between spaces in the twentieth-century urban fringes by using thoughtful densification. This redevelopment replaces asphalt with collective gardens while introducing diverse housing models like a CLT model to transform these fringes into neighborhoods. (T’Jonck, 2023)

Rethinking the urban - rural dichotomy

Lastly, we must acknowledge the ‘elephant in the room’: the enduring desire for homeownership, combined with the physical reality of privately owned housing, creates a systemic and material persistence that ensures this model will remain a central part of the landscape for the foreseeable future. This, of course, does not mean that we should discard the previously mentioned pathways; instead, we should perhaps take a different view of the territory we are dealing with, of which housing takes up a large portion. Much of urban history and its applications have focused on the centralized city, neglecting in-between, unplanned, and diffused territories (Grosjean, 2010). Even now, urban methods like densification and compact living are often suggested as generic solutions, however they repeatedly operate within the confines of a single plot, failing to provide a systemic alternative to the pattern of urbanization (Viganò et al., 2018, pp. 401–411). We should recognise that this territory has the largest share of negative externalities but also the greatest share of positive gains to be made. Thus, developing tools and methods for these areas, based upon the previously mentioned paths, is of importance, as these territories also provide interesting and unusual opportunities (Gheysen & Leemans, 2022; Mabilde & Muelenaere, 2025; Viganò et al., 2018; Vittorio Aureli & Tattara, 2021).



Fig 21.

The transformation of verkavelingswijken addresses the rural-urban dichotomy by moving beyond the confines of a single plot. By reframing these neighborhoods as a collective landscape rather than a collection of individual properties, it becomes possible to integrate supra-local ecological and social systems, such as water management and shared mobility solutions. In addition, they propose alternative models towards more collective dwelling types and modular densification. (Mabilde & Muelenaere, 2025)

Rather than neglecting these areas, these pathways advocate for the simultaneous pursuit of suitable housing alternatives, different ownership and management structures, and the careful ‘gardening’ of dispersed territories. This effectively flips current dependencies, where homeownership remains a dominant driver and outcome, into positive catalysts for future spatial and social equity.

Conclusion

In conclusion, this paper has demonstrated that the Belgian housing landscape and homeownership in particular, is a rigid product of path dependencies, shaped by the historical convergence of subsidized mass mobility, the active promotion of homeownership, and a lack of formal spatial planning. This asset-based welfare model historically provided a private safety net, but it has now reached its structural limits. Socio-economically, it marginalizes low-income groups and renters while widening the affordability gap. Spatially, it has produced a fragmented territory with the highest land take in the European Union, leading to various negative environmental effects.

Moving forward, we highlighted the importance of recognizing this path dependency as a prerequisite for steering the Belgian housing landscape in new directions. These alternative paths include providing suitable alternatives, closing the gap between policymakers, specialists and inhabitants and promoting alternative ownership structures. By rethinking the urban-rural dichotomy and implementing grounded strategies that acknowledge the existing structural inertia, these historical dependencies can be redirected towards a more socially and spatially equitable housing model.

However, certain limitations to these pathways remain. As this paper has demonstrated, these historical dependencies permeate all dimensions of society, not only housing policies. Future transitions should be equally multifaceted, operating across multiple fields simultaneously. Furthermore, while this essay outlines several prospective directions, the limitations of this scope mean these pathways require further detailed research. Ultimately, while these strategies offer hints for viable paths forward, the material and systemic persistence of the current homeownership model ensures it will remain a significant challenge for the foreseeable future.

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